

TERROIR

As with wine, each tea has its own character, and even teas of the same variety differ in flavor from region to region. This is due to the variation in interdependent conditions, known as *terroir*, or the ecosystem, in which the tea plant is grown.

The specific conditions in which the tea plant is grown play a big part in influencing its development and quality. Natural factors, such as altitude, soil, and climatic conditions, influence the flavor and character of the leaves, as well as the amount of vitamins, minerals, and other

compounds contained within them. While tea growers may hope for enough constants in the local environment to influence and control their harvest each year, nothing in nature is predetermined. Extreme weather, low rainfall, and poor soil may affect growth and, ultimately, the choices made for processing the leaves.

Growing on slopes

Plants grown on slopes benefit from good drainage. They will perish if left in soggy soil.

LATITUDE AND ALTITUDE

Tea bushes perform best in subtropical zones, between latitudes 40°N and 30°S of the Equator, which are neither too frosty nor too dry. Some tea-producing countries, such as Kenya, sit right on the Equator, but because the tea is grown in the highlands, the temperatures are cool enough for the tea plant to thrive.

Elevation

Tea can be grown at elevations as low as 400ft (125m) and as high as 8,000ft (2,450m) above sea level. The optimal elevation is around 6,500ft (2,000m), where temperatures are cooler and sunlight less abundant than on lower elevations.

8,000FT
(2,450M)

Roots

The roots hold the plant firmly in place on an incline, and absorb water and nutrients from the soil.

Soil

Loose, acidic soil (pH4.4–5.5) with a layer of organic compost is best for the tea plant. Heavy clay soil will inhibit growth of the taproot.

SEA LEVEL

